

Against trivializing fieldwork; or, why Tobati is perhaps not OSV.

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1. Introduction

Given that the large majority of the world's languages are spoken by smallish groups in non-urban settings and are not yet properly documented, it is clear that a serious engagement with linguistic diversity requires fieldwork. Fortunately, after a long period of neglect, the discipline has rediscovered the importance of fieldwork in the last few decades and significantly increased fieldworking activities. It has also become a widespread practice to include chapters on fieldwork languages in handbooks of various types (language family overviews, surveys on specific phenomena such as case, etc.), where 'fieldwork language' refers to languages which are only known to linguistics through fieldwork (see further below).

All of these developments are highly welcome, and it should be clear from the outset that the present contribution is strongly in favour not only of carrying out fieldwork, but also of publishing results from fieldwork at any stage of an ongoing project (i.e. ranging from a short, first-encounter wordlist to a large text collection or a full grammatical description). The present contribution is concerned with the fact that the renewed interest in fieldwork and data from fieldwork has largely failed to recognize that not all fieldwork is created equal. There is an obvious difference between a chapter on the basic case system of language X that is based on 30 years of continued and extensive work with a particular community, and a brief statement that is based on the first stay in a community lasting only a few hours or days. Ignoring this difference risks trivializing fieldwork whenever one is confronted with statements based on fieldwork data. The statement that language X has an ergative case is superficially the same regardless of whether the data basis is five hours of elicitation or years of working with a corpus of recorded natural speech.

To acknowledge the difference and avoid trivializing fieldwork means that publications based on fieldwork data must be clear about some basic parameters of data quality, including length of stay on location, number of speakers consulted, and rough amount of data collected. Unfortunately, this is not yet standardly the case, and one can easily find publications where the analysis of a well-documented language with millions of speakers and a hundred years of research is juxtaposed with the analysis of a language with a few hundred speakers and three weeks of fieldwork, without the necessary caveats. This is especially common in handbooks and thematic collections concerned with linguistic diversity.

Things become even more unbalanced and problematic when publications based on fieldwork make claims with regard to highly conspicuous and marked phenomena, such as the claim that a language's dominant word order is OSV (making it one of only four such languages currently listed in the World Atlas of Language Structures (WALS)), or that the language in question has very long, morphologically complex words. The current contribution provides short case studies on two languages for which exactly these claims have been made: Oceanic Tobati (OSV word order) and West Bomberai Iha ('exuberantly inflected verbs'). In both instances, the publications give no indication whatsoever of the data basis for their claims.

2. Cross-linguistically rare basic word order: the case of Tobati

One of the most robust findings of modern language-diversity research pertains to the basic order of the core constituents of basic declarative clauses such as *the cat chased the rat*, i.e. the transitive verb (V) *chase* and its two core arguments, *cat* and *rat*. The latter are usually

called *subject* (S) and *object* (O) in basic word order studies. They are defined ‘in a rather informal semantic sense, to denote the more agent-like and more patient-like’ (Dryer 2013a) core argument, respectively. There are two major findings of basic word order studies, which can be derived from the figures in Table 1. On the one hand, the languages of the world vary strongly with regard to their basic word orders. All six logically possible orders of the constituents S, O, and V appear to be attested. On the other hand, however, there are very clear preferences, i.e. not all possible orders are equally likely. Most frequently attested are orders in which the subject precedes the object. And there is also a strong preference for verbs to be in final or second position. Here we will be concerned only with the S-before-O bias, which is also known as the *agent-first bias*.

Basic word order	Frequency
Subject-object-verb (SOV)	564
Subject-verb-object (SVO)	488
Verb-subject-object (VSO)	95
Verb-object-subject (VOS)	25
Object-verb-subject (OVS)	11
Object-subject-verb (OSV)	4
Lacking a dominant word order	189
Total:	1376

Table 1: Basic word order patterns in the languages of the world (based on Dryer 2013a)

Before we proceed, it will be important to further clarify what is meant by ‘basic word order’. Dryer (2013b) provides the following definition, which is also applied here:

Where a language is shown ... as having a particular order as the dominant order in the language, this means that it is either the **only order possible** or the order that is **more frequently used**. (Dryer 2013b, emphasis in the original)

Dryer uses the term *dominant order* rather than *basic order* ‘to emphasize that priority is given here to the criterion of what is more frequent in language use, as reflected in texts’ (Dryer 2013b).

Ideally, then, statements on basic word order should be based on (rough) text counts, to confirm what is stated in the grammar(s) (see Dryer 2013b for some of the problems that arise when attempting to do this). Importantly, the candidates for basic word order(s) are also always limited by grammatical considerations. Grammars usually distinguish between a basic default order (or, more rarely, default orders) and more specific orders that are restricted to particular grammatical (e.g. relative clauses) or functional contexts (e.g. topic constructions). It is widely agreed, for example, that functionally specialized constructions such as topic constructions are not considered among the basic order candidates, even if they occur frequently in texts. Many, if not all, languages allow for object arguments to occur in topic position, as in the well-known English example *beans, I like*. The fact that *beans, I like* is possible in English does not imply that English allows basic OSV order. The important point here is that the object *beans* in the topic construction is neither prosodically nor syntactically part of the core clause. Rather, it is in an external position, as indicated by the comma. That

is, basic word order is a feature of declarative core clauses and not of just any construction involving a verb and two core arguments.

For English and many other languages, the facts regarding topic constructions and other non-basic clause constructions are widely agreed. For lesser known languages, these typically need explicit argumentation. Here, a proper argument for OSV as basic word order, *inter alia*, involves evidence that shows that the putatively basic OSV construction is not a topic construction.

After these preliminary remarks, let us take a closer look at the four OSV languages in WALS, listed in Table 2. The first point to note here is that the four languages come from very different areas and phyla. Hence, if these four cases of basic OSV order are all well supported, OSV would not be just an area-specific idiosyncrasy. Rather, there would be a certain likelihood that OSV is a rarely used, but still principally possible and universally available option for organizing basic clause structure. A second point is that all four languages can be considered typical fieldwork languages. That is, languages which do not have a (centuries-old) writing tradition,¹ are spoken by smallish communities, and often are only known through the work of a sole or small number of researchers. Claims about rare structural features in such languages demand particular scrutiny, as further discussed here in relation to the Austronesian language Tobati.

Kxoe	OSV	Köhler 1981: 539
Nadëb	OSV	Weir 1994: 292; Weir 1984: 271
Tobati	OSV	Donohue 2002: 186
Wik Ngathana	OSV	Sutton 1978: 303

Table 2: OSV languages in WALS and the sources for the claim that they are OSV (Dryer 2013a)

Tobati is the traditional language of two relatively small villages, Tobati and Enggros, located in Yotefa Bay in the Indonesian part of New Guinea, very close to the border with Papua New Guinea. The 2010 provincial census lists 371 inhabitants for Tobati and 368 for Enggros (Studi 2011: 104, 112). Administratively, both villages belong to Jayapura, the capital of Papua Province. The densely populated city can be reached in only 10–20 minutes, travelling across the bay by motor boat. Many Tobati in fact have houses in the city and live there most of the time. The language is severely endangered, as documented in detail in Studi (2011). The few remaining speakers are all over 60.

The claim that Tobati is an OSV language is found in Donohue (2002), and Donohue is the only author to date who has made this claim. The presentation of the claim in Donohue (2002:199) is rather short and worth quoting in full:²

¹ Today, translations of (parts of) the bible are available for quite a few fieldwork languages, leading to the inclusion of some literary practices in the local language ecology. This is not considered to be an instance of ‘having a writing tradition’ in the sense intended here.

² In this and the following examples quoted from Donohue (2002), morpheme breaks and glosses are reproduced from the source.

there is a clear and unambiguous preference for OSV order; SOV (or SVO) can still be obtained when eliciting from Indonesian, but translations from Tobati to Indonesian reveal that a sentence of the form NP NP V will be interpreted as OSV:

O	S	V	
<i>Hony-o</i>	<i>for-o</i>	<i>rom-i.</i>	
dog-FV	pig-FV	see-3SG	
'The pig saw the dog.'			*'The dog saw the pig.'

How much weight this statement carries very much depends on the quality of the fieldwork on which it is based. If written by someone who had worked with the community for a number of years, perhaps even decades, it would count as an expert assessment that could be accepted as is (unless, that is, there were some evidence that raised doubts about its validity). In this scenario, one would simply assume that the author was in a position to produce substantial further evidence to support the statement. But, if the OSV claim were based on only a few hours or days of fieldwork, perhaps only with one speaker, then one would be less inclined to consider the claim to be an established fact and would look for further evidence to support it.

In the present case, there is no information whatsoever regarding the fieldwork on which the grammar sketch is based. Hence, it is necessary to look more closely at the evidence presented in support of the claim, and also to look for other possible sources on Tobati word order. The following paragraphs will do just that, casting considerable doubt on the OSV claim for Tobati.

To begin with, it is not standard procedure to determine basic word order on the basis of back translations from the target language to the contact language (i.e. in this case from Tobati to Indonesian). Rather, as briefly reported above, the major evidence is provided by text frequencies, which do not appear to be available here. Strictly speaking, then, the evidence referred to by Donohue cannot be used to support a claim regarding basic word order (as defined in Dryer 2013b). Rather, it provides evidence for the claim that Tobati speakers do not heed the agent-first bias mentioned above. This bias pertains to the processing of simple transitive clauses and predicts that, in the absence of additional marking, an utterance such as *the cat the mouse chased* will be interpreted as the cat being the chaser, and the mouse being the one chased. 'Additional marking' could, for example, consist in an overt case marker (the mouse is overtly marked as the agent). But it would also include semantic-pragmatic plausibility (typically, cats chase mice and not the other way around).

There is strong cross-linguistic support for the agent-first bias (see Sauppe et al. (2023) for a recent summary). Hence, it would be highly significant if Tobati speakers did *not* exhibit this bias. However, to show this it would be necessary to set up a proper experiment, with a number of different speakers, a carefully crafted set of test items (avoiding biases from world knowledge and verb meanings, etc.), and a standard procedure for presenting the test items in a way that avoids introducing further confounds (e.g. if the test items were presented auditorily, one would have to ensure that a topic interpretation for the first noun phrase is excluded). There is no indication in Donohue (2002) how exactly it was determined that 'a sentence of the form NP NP V will be interpreted as OSV' by Tobati speakers (other than from back translations into Indonesian).

By chance, during a stay at the Universitas Papua in Manokwari (Indonesia) in 2025, the author of the present article happened to meet a local student, Jovanzka Sibi, who was able to

elicit speaker judgments on the *honyo foro romi* (dog pig see) example above on location in Tobati. The main purpose of this exercise, which is documented in full in the *Language Archive Cologne* (HANDLE), was to show how problematic such elicitations can be. Only two native speakers could be found to participate in the experiment. The sentence was read by a community member who is not a native speaker. Both participants agreed that the meaning of *honyo foro romi* is ‘the dog saw the pig’ (i.e. that the word order is SOV). However, given the circumstances under which these judgments were elicited and the small number of data points (2 speakers, 6 sentences taken from Donohue 2002 and Purba 2005), the results in themselves do not prove anything one way or the other. They may become relevant in a larger pool of data on Tobati word order. For now, the main merit of the experiment consists in the fact that it is the only data for Tobati for which an audio recording is available.

Turning to further problems regarding the OSV claim, we find that there are other sources on Tobati that state that the basic word order is SOV. One such source is Cowan (1952), the only source on Tobati that is also cited in Donohue (2002:198). Donohue does not doubt Cowan’s SOV claim. Rather, he claims that a word order change from SOV to OSV has happened in the roughly 50 years that lie between Cowan’s work on Tobati and his own. He writes:³

There appears to have been a recent syntactic change in Tobati, in which the order of the constituents has changed. In earlier elicited materials, we find a preference for SOV word order, as in the following sentences from Cowan (1952):

S	O	V	
Mony	ndo	inti	hony re rekoc.
woman	that	her	dog RE hit
‘The woman hits her dog.’			

Here we can see that, in the absence of pronominal information on the verb that would differentiate the subject and the object (the *re* morpheme is probably the 3PL subject prefix *r-*, and so could refer to either the woman (women), or the dog(s), and so does not help to identify grammatical relations), the word order is used for this purpose with the default assumption that given two NPs the subject precedes the object, giving an SOV word order. Additionally, the real-world fact that women hit dogs but dogs do not hit women helps to disambiguate the clause. (Donohue 2002: 198f)

While Cowan (1952) clearly predates Donohue (2002), there are further publications on Tobati that are in part concurrent with Donohue (2002), specifically Purba et al. (1996) and Purba (1999, 2005). Others are clearly more recent: Mantiri (2012), Nurlia (2012), and Aryanti (2015). All these sources explicitly state that Tobati has basic SOV word order, and all of their examples with two overt NPs actually show SOV order.⁴ All these sources,

³ To the best of my knowledge, there is no dedicated publication regarding the claim that word order change has occurred in Tobati in the second half of the 20th century. Glottolog (Hammarström et al. 2024) lists a handout among the publications for Tobati (Donohue, Mark. 2002. SVO to OSV: extreme word order change in Tobati. Ms. 6pp.), which does not seem to be accessible online (anymore?). This handout will not be discussed here as it is not a peer-reviewed publication. Importantly for current purposes, it does not contain data or analyses for Tobati that are not also found in Donohue (2002).

⁴ With one minor exception: in addition to many SOV examples with two overt core arguments, Mantiri (2012:51) provides three examples for what she calls a passive construction. In this construction, the patient argument precedes the agent argument, the result superficially looking like an OSV construction. The rather terse discussion does not suffice to determine the defining features of this construction. In particular, it is not clear whether the construction is transitive or intransitive.

excepting Purba (2005), which appeared in an Indonesian linguistics journal, are research reports for the National Language Institute (*Badan Pengembangan dan Pembinaan Bahasa*), or BA or MA theses from local universities. They are usually only accessible on location and are exclusively based on questionnaires in Indonesian, which tend to be very schematic. Furthermore, they are typically based on very short fieldwork (usually a few days, rarely weeks). However, unlike Cowan (1952) and Donohue (2002), the Indonesian sources provide detailed information on the data gathering procedures, listing all speakers interviewed, providing details about the where and when of the field stay(s), and reproducing the questionnaire used in an appendix. In this way, one can easily assess the limitations of these works, but still make use of the valuable information they typically also contain.

For our current concern – basic word order in Tobati – the two examples from Purba (2005:14) in (1) provide information not found in Donohue (2002).⁵

- 1 a) *Markus anyi-t h-je-ic.*
 Mark mother-ALL 3SG-call-3SG.OBJ
 'Markus calls mother' (Purba 2005:14/ex 27)
- b) *Marta shai-re y-a.*
 Marta taro-? 3SG-eat
 'Marta eats taro.' (Purba 2005:14/ex 28)

Both examples illustrate SOV order regardless of whether or not the verb has a suffix for the undergoer argument (*-ic* in example (1a)). Importantly, Purba and the other Indonesian sources present objects as consistently marked with a suffix, either the allative marker *-Vt* or the suffix *-re*. The allative appears to be obligatory for pronouns, proper names, and kin terms, and optional for animates, while *-re* mostly occurs with inanimates, which suggests the existence of a *Differential Object Marking* system. The form *-re*, labelled an object (or accusative) marker in the Indonesian sources, appears to be identical to what Donohue calls a subject prefix in the quote above.⁶

It is thus unclear from the currently available sources how case marking in Tobati works. At the same time, it is very likely that case marking plays a major role in determining basic word order. Donohue himself (2002:199) notes in the continuation of the quote given above:

When verbal indexing makes the reference of the core arguments unambiguous, then this order is relaxed. The following sentence shows the optional use of the allative case to mark an object, and the appearance of SOV, rather than OSV, word order.

Nehu man ros(-ad) j-om-ric.
 1SG bird two-ALL 1SG-see-3PL
 'I saw two birds.' (Donohue 2002: 199)

Apart from OS order, there appear to be changes to the case marking of the two core arguments and to the person marking on the verb.

⁵ Grammatical glosses and morpheme boundaries added by NPH. Note that, according to Purba (1999:107-118) and the other Indonesian sources, some verb forms are also marked for a five-way tense distinction, which is typical for many non-Austronesian languages in the area. No attempt has been made to represent tense marking in the glossing. Donohue does not mention any tense/aspect/mood distinctions.

⁶ Donohue (2002:190f) provides a table of the pronoun forms, including pronominal affixes. In this table, the 3PL subject prefix is given as *ry-* (and not simply as *r-*). Furthermore, Donohue (2002:199) includes a list of case marking suffixes. In this list, *-re* is glossed as 'focus'.

Returning to the OSV example in the first quote from Donohue (2002) above, i.e. *hony-o for-om-i* 'the pig saw the dog', we may now note that both NPs have a suffix *-o*, which is glossed as 'FV'. The gloss, however, is neither resolved ('final vowel'?) nor commented on. This example is the only example in all the materials on Tobati available to the present author where NPs are marked by an *-o* suffix, which raises the suspicion that it is not really representative of a basic unmarked construction. In this regard, it may be worth mentioning that Donohue's chapter contains a total of 35 examples with two overt NPs, of which 23 show SOV order. Of course, this being a highly condensed grammatical sketch, it may well be that a majority of the examples show non-basic word order because the constructions illustrated with these examples demand non-OSV order. However, in no instance the possibility is mentioned that SOV order is triggered by the grammatical context.

The preceding observations suggest that it is premature to consider Tobati a language with basic OSV order. To be clear: I do not object to making strong claims about basic word order in a grammatical sketch. But such claims should be sufficiently hedged, and must be anchored to a statement on the kind and quality of the (fieldwork) data it is based on. This would draw attention to the fact that the issue requires further exploration, which, it seems to me, is clearly the case here.

It bears emphasizing that word order generalizations in terms of S, O, and V are only one step in charting the 'usual' and the 'unusual' in the study of clause structure. If we assume, along with much of the literature, that ordering the agent before the patient (the S before the O) is the default (due to a cognitive processing bias), the interesting question is when and why speakers would 'override' the processing bias and choose the opposite order. We still lack good hypotheses as to why some speech communities use this order with such high frequency that it is deemed noteworthy by fieldworking researchers.

Note that the strength of the evidence for OSV in the four candidate languages in Table 2 differs dramatically. Excluding Tobati as a fairly weak case from further consideration, the Brazilian OSV language Nadëb appears to be the most promising candidate for a 'true' OSV language (or at least one in which OSV is among the more frequently attested word orders). In part, this is simply due to the fact that Nadëb is spoken in an area where O-initial orders, i.e. both OVS and OSV, are 'common' (cp. Derbyshire & Pullum 1981, *inter alia*). Six of the eleven languages classified as OVS in Table 1 are Amazonian, and pertinent claims have been made by a number of different researchers.

More importantly, Nadëb is the only one of the remaining three languages in Table 2 for which there is a proper discussion of the OSV claim in the available sources. In particular, Weir (1984:270-284) provides a detailed discussion of word-order options and preferences in Nadëb. She concludes that among the two major candidates for basic word order, OSV and SVO, it is the former that occurs more frequently in her texts, and hence could be considered the basic word order (see also Derbyshire & Pullum 1981:208f). More recently, Epps and colleagues carried out a community workshop to discuss native-speaker ideas about the difference between OSV and SVO order (Epps et al. 2021). OSV appears to be considered the more traditional order, while SVO is seen as newer and is, in part at least, more strongly associated with the bible translation.⁷

To my mind, then, there is sufficiently strong evidence from both elicitation and texts that OSV is among the basic ordering options in Nadëb, and that native speakers actually also

⁷ Many thanks to Pattie Epps for sharing her insights on Nadëb in personal communication.

recognize it as such (whether it is ‘dominant’ in the strict sense of Dryer 2013a/b is less clear, as all sources show that SVO is also quite frequent). To date, no good hypothesis concerning what motivates the choice of OSV order has been proposed, but there is a recent documentary collection (Epps et al. 2018) which promises the opportunity for a productive study of this issue.

As for Wik Ngathana, the source referenced for the OSV claim in Table 2 is very brief:

Most sentences which contain verbs place a verb last. Non-polar questions which lack verbs tend to end in interrogative pronouns. The most common order in transitive sentences is OBJECT-SUBJECT-VERB. Deictic complexes and aspectual and modal particles, in that order, generally come immediately before the verb. Word order is, however, very free. (Sutton 1978: 303)

The cited work is a sociolinguistic PhD thesis (entitled *Wik: Aboriginal Society, Territory and Language at Cape Keerweer*), the quote being drawn from an appendix providing a grammar sketch. At the time of finishing the thesis, the author had done fieldwork in and with Wik communities for almost 24 months in total, and actually spoke one of the Wik dialects. Thus, despite its brevity, the quoted statement should be taken as an expert judgment based on substantial experience. Still, for typological concerns, the final sentence demands that word order variation is more thoroughly investigated and a more systematic investigation of frequencies is undertaken before OSV basic word order can be considered to be sufficiently well established.

Finally, the inclusion of Kxoe among the OSV languages is questionable because the sources are not unequivocal. Köhler (1981) makes a major distinction between clauses where the grammatical function of the verbal arguments (subject or object) is overtly marked (mostly through gender-marking suffixes), and those where it remains unmarked. In the latter case, the order is SOV or SVO (Köhler 1981:539). When grammatical roles are overtly marked, five different orders are possible: OSV, SOV, SVO, OVS, and VSO. While Köhler characterizes OSV as the ‘*type prédominant*’, he also says that it involves ‘*emphase sur l’object*’, which suggests that this is a marked order rather than a default order.⁸ The sheer number of possible orders suggests that this is a language with no basic word order. This is, in essence, also the conclusion arrived at by Kilian-Hatz (2008:47-53) in her more recent and more comprehensive description of the language.⁹

To summarize: while the evidence for OSV is stronger for Nadëb and Wik Ngathana, for none of the four languages has the claim that they show basic OSV order in the strict sense of Dryer (2013a/b) been established beyond reasonable doubt. What is missing in particular are careful studies that clarify the following two issues: First, whether there are speech communities, including the four communities discussed here, that consistently avoid the agent-first bias in an experimental setting (i.e. when interpreting a construction in which both arguments of a transitive verb are plausible agents). Second, what exactly the typical usage

⁸ In an unpublished German version of the grammatical sketch, which is dated 1973, Köhler lists only four possible orders for clauses with overt arguments marked for gender: SVO, OSV, OVS, and SOV. In this version, he claims that the last one (SOV) is the default order (‘*Diese Stellung der Satzteile ist sehr gebräuchlich und stellt das Standardmuster dar*’ (Köhler 1973:85)). See further next footnote.

⁹ Kilian-Hatz (2008) claims that three orders are common in Khwe (the name of the language she uses instead of the older Kxoe): SOV, which is common in elicitation; SVO, which is most common in texts (a claim based on an actual text count (2008:48); and OSV, which is used when the object is pragmatically prominent.

contexts for OSV constructions are, where ‘usage contexts’ are understood in a broad sense, including discourse structure as well as sociolinguistic settings. Ideally, understanding these usage contexts will contribute to understanding why, in some social and discursal contexts, speakers override the agent-first bias and place objects before subjects.

2. ‘Exuberantly inflected’ verbs in Iha?

The second example¹⁰ illustrating the relevance of basic fieldwork information for evaluating descriptive analyses and their typological implications pertains to the fact that the size and structure of words varies across languages. In fact, one of the first ideas for typologizing language structures was to group them into different classes according to the prevailing word structure, resulting in the well-known holistic typology of isolating, agglutinating, inflecting, and polysynthetic languages. Nowadays, it is widely agreed that this typology is highly questionable, since it has so far not been possible to show that different morphological profiles systematically correlate with other structural features of natural languages (Comrie 1989:42-52 and many others). Furthermore, there are many conceptual issues regarding the basic units (e.g. words, roots, clitics, affixes) and processes (e.g. fusion, incorporation) which render the existing definitions of the four morphological types highly problematic (see Plank 1999 for pertinent discussion, among others).

Polysynthesis is probably the most problematic concept, and it is widely agreed that no definition exists that properly delimits a group of languages showing sufficiently similar morphological profiles to consider them a ‘type’ (Zúñiga 2019 provides a succinct summary of the state of the art). Still, it is also clear that languages differ significantly with regard to the size and structure of their words, and that we are still a long way from being able to comprehensively map out the variation space for wordhood in natural languages.

In order to be able to say that words are short or long, complex or simple, we obviously have to be able to define the boundaries of words. The theoretical and typological discussion in the preceding decades has centred on the observation that word boundaries defined by commonly used criteria do not necessarily match. Following Dixon (1977), it is now common practice to distinguish prosodic (or phonological) from morphosyntactic (or grammatical) words. The former are defined by prosodic criteria (prosodic prominence, phonological alternations, phonotactics, etc.), while the latter involve morphosyntactic criteria (selectivity, ordering, paradigmatic organization, etc.).

In some languages criteria from both levels converge in delimiting a word-like unit, in others they do not. What is more, it has now also become clear that the criteria on each level do not necessarily converge, resulting in multiple, non-isomorphic word candidates on both levels (e.g. the prosodic word as defined by voicing alternations vs the prosodic word as defined by prosodic prominence). Schiering et al. (2010) thus argue that in some languages, wordhood is not necessarily a fixed given, but is rather a continuously changing, emerging unit (see also Tallman 2020 for references and discussion, and Bickel & Zúñiga 2017 for two in-depth examples).

¹⁰ It is most unfortunate that both case studies discussed here involve publications by Mark Donohue. Without doubt, similar cases of missing information regarding the quality of fieldwork data have occurred – and continue to occur – all around the world. The main reason for using the two case studies presented here is the fact that the current author has firsthand knowledge of the two languages, fieldsites, and native speaker communities, which makes it much easier to discuss problematic aspects of data collection and processing.

The possibility of multiple word candidates raises not only a number of theoretical problems, but also a variety of practical issues. The major practical problem that arises in fieldwork and in grammar writing concerns the decision on which of the multiple word-like units to select as the one represented in writing. This is a very important decision, because even if it is stated clearly and frequently in a corpus of transcriptions or a descriptive grammar that the chosen orthographic word unit is only one of a number of possibilities, this unit will influence writers and readers in their (interpretation of the proposed grammatical) analyses. In the following, I will call the analyses and decisions to be made in this regard simply ‘the wordhood problem’.

Despite its fundamental importance, there is surprisingly little discussion or literature on how to deal with the wordhood problem in fieldwork. In the initial stages of fieldwork, there are two things that happen more or less simultaneously. On the one hand, in both elicitation and in transcription, native speakers are prompted to produce word-sized units that can be written down. To be successful in this task presupposes a shared idea about wordhood, which is constantly negotiated between native speaker and researcher.¹¹ On the other hand, the researcher constantly has to decide whether or not the string offered by the native speaker is in fact word-sized.

Note that many other decisions which arise in the initial stages of fieldwork – determining the meaning of a certain unit, say, or deciding whether a certain sound is voiced or voiceless – can be deferred to a later stage, for instance by leaving a gap, inventing a special symbol for undecided cases, or using question marks. While in principle, decisions on orthographic wordhood can also be deferred to a certain extent (by writing down a unit offered by the native speaker as one or two (or three) words), it is not feasible to do this for a great number of items. Developing and applying conventions for orthographic words, then, happens very quickly, and in an interactional setup between speaker(s) and researcher(s) that to date has not been investigated to any significant extent. That is, we currently know very little about how wordhood problems are resolved in fieldwork. We only know the results as manifest in transcriptions and publications.

Over time, of course, conventions adopted at an early stage may change. However, one should not underestimate the normative power of established practices, even if these were only intended to be preliminary. In an ideal world, the process of documenting and describing a so-far undescribed language culminates in a grammatical description that comprehensively discusses mismatches between word-sized domains and explicitly motivates the choice of one of these domains as the one represented in the practical orthography used in all written materials on the language (examples in the grammar, transcripts, elicitation notes). Often, this form will then also serve as the headword (lemma) for entries in a dictionary or lexical database.

¹¹ The role of the native speaker in determining wordhood continues to be severely underestimated and understudied. Ultimately, it is the word-sized chunks that native speakers offer the researchers in elicitation on which all further morphological analyses are based. See Himmelmann (1987:16–21, *passim*) for further discussion, including of the fact that this practice provides the most basic definition of ‘a word’ in a particular language, which follows Bloomfield’s famous ‘minimum free form’ definition: words are the minimal units speakers provide as answers to concept questions in elicitation, i.e. questions that ask for names of concepts.

In languages where there are no, or only very minor, mismatches between word domains, this process will not last long. In this case, the practices for writing word-sized units established in the first few hours of fieldwork turn out to be robust and do not need major adjustments. In others, such as Tibeto-Burmese Chintang and the isolate Mapudungun, both discussed in Bickel & Zúñiga (2017), the process is still ongoing after decades of research. So, wordhood is a topic where results from fieldwork tend to differ significantly between different field sites and research traditions. While the lengths of fieldwork stays also play a role here, in this case the structure of the language is much more relevant in determining the time it takes to come up with a well-supported decision on which unit is chosen to be represented by the orthographic word in the practical orthography. Since this is not directly discernible to the reader of a paper based on fieldwork data, it should be common practice to provide a short indication as to the existence of possible wordhood problems, regardless of the topic of the publication. This could be as simple as distinguishing between ‘no major wordhood problems’, ‘problems resulting from multiple non-converging word domains largely resolved’, and ‘problems resulting from multiple non-converging word domains still to be resolved’. Of course, if there is a grammar or a special publication addressing wordhood issues, then a reference to these would fully suffice.

To illustrate the kind of problems readers can be confronted with regarding wordhood, let us look at an example from Iha, which is spoken on the Onin Peninsula (West Papua, Indonesia) and has been argued to be part of the Greater West Bomberai (sub)family (Usher & Schapper 2022). The author has first-hand experience with Iha, mostly from working on, and with, a documentary corpus that was initiated by Narfafan & Tutuop (2009-2016), and is presently being further enlarged and annotated by Emanuel Tutuop, Katherine Walker, and the author. In 2016, the author spent three weeks in the regional capital, Fakfak, and the surrounding Iha-speaking area with native speaker Emanuel Tutuop, eliciting missing forms in paradigms, checking meanings and grammar in the corpus data, and recording new data. Walker & Himmelmann (accepted) summarizes our understanding of Iha grammar up to mid-2023. Katherine Walker spent two months in the Iha-speaking area, primarily in Fakfak and Sipatnanam, in October and November 2024. A second two-month trip in November and December 2025 was the first time that a member of our research team stayed in another dialect area, i.e. the central mountains in the northeastern part of the Iha speaking area. Our corpus previously contained very little data from that area, which seems to have been the focus of a chapter on Iha verbal inflections by Mark Donohue, to which we now turn.¹²

In a contribution to *The Oxford Handbook of Inflection*, Donohue (2015:407) presents ‘a pair of rather full examples of different inflectional categories on the [Iha] verb’, which he also characterizes as ‘exuberantly inflected’. One of the two examples is reproduced here in (2). The two words in the first line (*mige*, the third person pronoun *mi* followed by the focus-marking clitic =*ge*, and *koret*, the word for ‘food’) are unremarkable. What is remarkable is the word which takes up all of the second line and, without hyphens, reads *newepymyannyatnanweradembihptyebon*. This word is remarkable not only for its overall length, but also for the multitude of formatives that follow the initial verbal stem *newé* ‘eat’, which appear to be partially grammatical, and partially lexical. The last line is also unusual in that it appears to be the opposite of the second line: a one-syllable word with grammatical meaning.

¹² Donohue (2015:405) says: “the variety described here is the mother-tongue of the inner north of the peninsula.”

- 2 “Exuberantly inflected verbs in Iha” (example 3b in Donohue 2015:408); morpheme breaks, glosses, and translation as in the original¹³

Mi-ge koret
3-FOC food

newe-py-myan-nyatna-n-wera-de-mb-ih-t-pye-b-o-n
eat-REPET-direct-like.that-CONJ-very.many-CONT-YPAST-3-EVID-REPET-12PAST-12-1 SG

pya.
ASSERT

'He kept on eating all sorts of things, for an extended time, again and again, and I witnessed it multiply and repeatedly, so do not doubt me.'

There is no information regarding the fieldwork on which the chapter is based. More specifically, there is no indication whatsoever as to the evidence that has been used in determining that the string of morphemes in the second line of (2) forms a single Iha word. Example (2) is one of only two examples of its kind in the whole chapter. In all other examples, verbs generally have maximally two suffixes and one prefix. Example (3) illustrates the ‘standard’ example, with an overt topic pronoun, which is not grammatically necessary, and the verb stem followed by a tense and a person suffix.

- 3 Example 5a in Donohue (2015:409); morpheme breaks, glosses, and translation as in the original

On-a mbyar knó-mb-on.
1SG-TOP dog see-YPST-1SG
'I saw a/the dog yesterday.'

Elicited examples in our corpus also typically look like example (3). There is no form that is even remotely similar to the ‘exuberantly inflected’ word in example (2). We have discussed the latter example with seven different speakers from the southern dialect area, for all of whom the example sounded strange and was not considered proper Iha. No speaker was able to produce the whole word, not even with hesitations and restarts. An eighth speaker, living in the northern dialect area, seemed to be able to roughly understand the example after carefully studying a written version and taking apart the very long string of letters in line 2. He was more or less able to pronounce it and to repeat parts of it in a different order. Importantly, all attempts to produce the complete sentence are very clearly chunked into smaller units. However, he also said it wasn’t his dialect, so there was still something not quite right about it for him.

To be sure, speakers easily and consistently recognized segments of the overall string. The third person pronoun *mi(ge)*, *koret* ‘food’,¹⁴ and the verb stem *newé* are easily recognized and also occur frequently in our data. Similarly, *wera* ‘many, become adult, big’ is frequently used both as a predicate and as a modifier; *wera dembih* occurs as a clause meaning ‘they were

¹³ There is no list of abbreviations for this chapter. There is a general list of abbreviations for the whole volume which contains standard abbreviations such as EVID(ential) or FOC(us). It does not include more special abbreviations such as YPAS (probably ‘yesterday’s past’) and REPET(itive?). Unclear are CONJ, which appears to refer to ‘conjugation class’, and CONT, which is included in the general list of abbreviations and said to refer to ‘localization indicating contact with the landmark, normally with the object being somehow fixed on it’. It is not clear that the latter is actually relevant for the Iha chapter.

¹⁴ Donohue writes <koret> and <wera> as he does not represent the phonemic distinction between high vs low mid vowels (cp. Donohue 2015:405).

many' or 'it was a lot', where we analyse *dembih* as consisting of an auxiliary stem *te* (optionally *de* after vowel) followed by the third person past suffix *-mbih*. The remaining constituents are less clear. The string *t-pye-b-o-n* was interpreted as *de-vi-evon* (say-progressive-first singular immediate past).¹⁵ The string *pymyannyatnan* proved particularly difficult to produce and interpret. It may contain the directional verb stem *m(i)yá* 'to there (andative)' and the suffix *-nan*, which often occurs at the end of (non-finite?) verb forms indicating continuation. In short, it is far from clear that the second line of example (2) is actually an example of an 'exuberantly inflected verb'. It may very well be a chain of clauses, roughly translatable as 'he ate food continuously, it was a lot, I said it', with four or five constituent words. This is also the chunking found in the spoken production attempts by the eighth speaker.¹⁶

Note that presenting such an example to native speakers to check its validity is fraught with problems. Iha speakers generally do not write or read their language. Hence, reading the example is generally not a presentational option. Western researchers trying to read it out loud inevitably produces some partially unintelligible garble. In this case, speakers pick out the bits they can make sense of and provide an interpretation for those. This then basically leads to chunking the example into smaller units, presenting them one after another to the native speakers for feedback. In other words, the method used in presenting the example is already strongly biased towards producing word-like units. Presenting the example in an Indonesian translation (based on the English provided by Donohue) did not fare any better, as this translation also suggests clausal and phrasal units, rather than a large word unit.

To sum up, at this stage it does not seem very likely that Iha verb inflection is particularly 'exuberant', but rather belongs to the category of languages with a moderate degree of prefixing and suffixing. However, there is still a long way to go before this can be considered a confirmed fact. There is always the possibility that the example was not presented well enough for the speakers to be able to recognize it. Or that it belongs to a speaking style mastered only by a few speakers. And so on.

Most importantly, perhaps, it is not the case that there are no known wordhood problems in Iha. Quite the opposite. In our sketch chapter on Iha, we write:

Vowel copying is one of a number of phenomena that could be taken as evidence for delimiting the boundaries of prosodic words, including voicing assimilation, haplology, resyllabification, and prosodic prominence ('stress'). While prosodic wordhood in Iha is a complex matter, little understood so far, it is clear that the domains defined by these phenomena do not fully overlap and often include more than one content word, hence possibly being indicative of prosodic domains larger than prosodic words. (Walker & Himmelmann, accepted, section 3).

So, it may very well be possible that there is a prosodic domain that matches what Donohue calls a 'word' in relation to example (2). And there is a (minor?) chance that there are good arguments that this domain is chosen for representation as an orthographic word. However, failing either to indicate the stage one is at in deciding orthographic wordhood in a field language, or to provide at least a few keywords as to what kind of evidence played a role in

¹⁵ Donohue writes the bilabial fricative with ; we use <v> in line with local preferences. Fricatives generally become stops after consonants (hence [py-evon] not [vy-evon]).

¹⁶ A reviewer correctly observes that the example appears to contain at least two instances of the person-tense suffixes characterizing finite Iha verbs, suggesting a minimum of two different verbs.

the decision trivializes fieldwork: choosing orthographic words is more than simply typing an empty space after a bunch of segments.

3. Fieldwork is diverse

The preceding discussion conveys a seemingly trivial message: fieldwork is diverse and this diversity should be made visible in analyses based on fieldwork data. There are very many factors that contribute to the success of fieldwork and the quality of its results. At its best, it provides key insights into the nature of language, both as a cognitive and a social structure, insights for which there is no other source because every language has its own unique properties. Unsurprisingly, the more important insights are often not directly accessible, but require long-term data collection with different methods and in different settings. Realistically speaking, the ideal¹⁷ fieldwork that provides for a comprehensive understanding of all the many idiosyncrasies of the linguistic practices employed by a speech community is often not possible. This is generally not the investigators' 'fault', as resources and enabling factors of all kinds, including time and funding, climate and politics, are at play.

Given the reality of language endangerment, and with it the very real prospect that many of the languages currently still spoken around world will be impossible to study at all, I am strongly in favour of publishing/making accessible fieldwork results at any time during the process, as already stated on the first page. Acknowledging the diversity of outcomes means that any such publication should provide an indication of the major parameters known to influence the quality of any further analyses that might be based on it. Parameters include language-external factors, such as a rough indication of the time spent on data collection, the degree of immersion in the community, the number of speakers involved in the work, etc. But they also include some linguistic factors that cannot be easily deduced from the publication itself, as in the case of wordhood, where the way words are presented on the page generally does not - or indeed cannot - convey whether wordhood decisions were easily resolved or are still ongoing. Written data, after all, (nearly) always look orderly.

The most efficient way to provide the relevant information is proper archiving of all field data with sufficient metadata. Then a simple reference to the documentary collection will suffice. Note that it is not only authors who should ensure that sufficient quality information for the fieldwork data they use is included in a publication: editors of journals, handbooks, and similar share the responsibility here.

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¹⁷ While one would assume that linguists can roughly agree on what an ideal outcome of linguistic fieldwork would be, there are certainly many disagreements as to the best way of achieving it, a topic not further pursued here.

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